

Incident Alert: 0040 TLP: CLEAR			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	RO	Georgescu's Unexpected Win: A Story of Algorithmic Manipulation	0 2/12/2024	2

Summary

- Calin Georgescu's success in the first round of the elections has been attributed to an inauthentic coordinated campaign on TikTok.
- The campaign manipulated the TikTok algorithm using the accounts hiding their affiliations that were likely organised via Telegram groups which incentivised users to participate in the manipulative campaign with contests.
- This Romanian case should act as a warning for how similar tactics might be mirrored in future European elections,
- Alliance4Europe has connected Romanian civil society to European regulators and calls on TikTok to investigate the potential coordinated inauthentic campaigns on their platform and publish the results.

Incident

The Romanian Presidential elections of the 24th of November 2024 were unexpectedly won by Calin Georgescu, an independent candidate who achieved this through a heavy social media campaign (mainly on TikTok) and with very little physical presence.

Calin Georgescu's unexpected success in Romania's presidential elections is attributed to a coordinated TikTok campaign. His account gained over 150 million views in two months, boosted by coordinated amplification flagged by Expert Forum. Influencers used the hashtag #echilibrușiverticalitate to subtly promote his messages of neutrality and economic independence. A Telegram group, "Propagatorcg," orchestrated the manipulation, instructing users to tweak and repost content to avoid detection as bots.

Narrative - separate with ;

N/A

Impact

N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework) (Max 2 objectives and 4 TTPs).

Objective: [Cultivate Support for Ally](#) - The influence operation covered in this report aimed to cultivate support for Georgescu.

[Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#) - Based on our findings and the report of Expert Forum, there were coordinated attempts to promote Georgescu by manipulating TikTok's algorithm.

[Conceal Network Identity](#) - The coordination of the accounts flooding TikTok was not transparent about the coordinated nature of the campaign.

[Use Contests and Prizes](#) - According to G4media.ro, some of the Telegram Groups were making competitions out of the coordinated amplification.

[T0049: Flood Information Space](#) - The attempts to manipulate TikTok's algorithm were done in a coordinated manner flooding TikTok with content promoting Georgescu.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Established connections with Romanian civil society and connected them with European regulators. Alliance4Europe aims to support local actors as best we can.

Recommendations: TikTok should investigate the alleged coordinated inauthentic campaign and publish the results. Further investigations should also be made in the Telegram channels used to coordinate.

Repo rt	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Elections, Romania, far-right.	See report.	C.B, Alliance4Europe, Editor: Saman Nazari,.	Messages, videos.	Telegram, TikTok